

Reed Smith

Complete firm and application research — scale & locations, sectors, values, culture, learning & development, pro bono, 2026 regulatory landscape, apprenticeship structure and personal notes.

- Scale:** ~3,000 people, 1,600+ lawyers, 30+ offices — US, Europe, Middle East, Asia
- Apprenticeship:** First-ever solicitor apprentices welcomed September 2026
- London office:** Largest office firmwide — 300+ lawyers, Blossom Yard & Studios
- Values:** Authentic, Collaborative, Forward Looking, Committed

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1. Firm Overview & Scale

- A team of around 3,000 people, including more than 1,600 lawyers, working across more than 30 offices in the United States, Europe, the Middle East and Asia
- Offers the platform, resources and reach of a major international law firm, while maintaining the supportive, team-oriented environment of a smaller firm
- Top 25 law firm by lawyer count
- Focus on being genuinely top of the game in its chosen practice areas — unbeatable, tailored expert service, rather than pressure to be a full-service firm in every area
- Around half of staff are non-lawyers — giving strong market understanding and a constant eye for efficiency gaps, and making business understanding essential firmwide
- Recently made its office layout more open-plan and non-hierarchical, to encourage collaboration and approachability

2. Locations

London — the firm's largest office

Situated in the redeveloped Blossom Yard & Studios, combining state-of-the-art facilities with a blend of heritage and contemporary design. Home to over 300 lawyers and nearly as many professional staff, designed with flexibility and sustainability in mind.

Global footprint

- Still expanding — new offices in Atlanta and Denver, counterbalancing the closure of the Beijing office (following other US firms pulling back from mainland China)
- Still retains an office in Shanghai, alongside roughly 30 other international hubs
- A handful of trainees/apprentices get international secondment experience each year — recent destinations include Paris, Dubai and Singapore
- Client secondments have included Channel 4, Barclays Bank and IKEA

3. Sectors & Practice Areas

The firm works across five main sectors: **Energy & Natural Resources, Entertainment & Media, Financial Services, Health Care & Life Sciences, and Transportation** — plus strengths in litigation, transactional work, private client, private equity and M&A.

AdTech

One of the world's leading advertising and technology law firms. The cross-functional, multi-jurisdictional AdTech team combines expertise in advertising/marketing, data privacy and security, IP, technology transactions, information governance, compliance/enforcement, and litigation.

Entertainment & Media / PE

Represents some of the most prolific companies in the music industry, having negotiated and advised on many of the highest-value, highest-profile transactions in recent years. Trusted advisor to name-brand advertisers, production companies, media companies, tech companies, publishers, film studios, TV networks, cable channels, trade associations, authors, musicians and celebrities.

Deep industry insight across financial services, health care and life sciences, energy, transportation, and entertainment and media allows the firm to proactively identify emerging risks, build litigation strategies aligned with the client's business and regulatory landscape, and protect long-term value.

4. Clients

- Niche in private capital, but also works with household names and high-net-worth individuals
- Client list includes all top 10 banks in the US, UK and EU, plus major tech companies and global pop stars
- Finance sector clients include JP Morgan and HSBC

5. Values

Firm values: **Authentic, Collaborative, Forward Looking, Committed** — each with a specific internal nuance.

- Fosters a respectful, inclusive culture where every individual has an equal opportunity to succeed
- Engages with unique perspectives and talents; promotes dynamic collaboration and fairness
- Respect and inclusion are seen as empowering people to do their best work

6. Culture

- Mentorship and mutual respect are central — partners, counsel and associates are accessible and committed to helping one another gain experience and strengthen client relationships
- Firmwide retreats, cross-border collaboration and shared initiatives connect lawyers across offices and practice groups
- A sociable ethos carries over after working hours — well-attended evenings out, plus sports teams (softball, football, cricket) and firmwide socials
- Business Inclusion Groups open to trainees: **MCN** (Multicultural), **PRISM** (LGBTQ+), **LEADRS** (Disability), **WINRS** (Women's Initiative Network), and the Mental Health Taskforce
- Culture is being actively shaped through "tone at the top" messaging and innovative programming focused on inclusive behaviour

Reed Smith's sociable ethos was carried over after working hours. It was good to see that people didn't spend their whole lives at their desk.

— Trainee account

7. Learning & Development

- Structured legal and professional/business skills programmes throughout a lawyer's career lifecycle, from trainee/summer associate through to counsel and partnership
- Trainee programme includes a comprehensive induction, seat rotations, and support from a dedicated Trainee Academy; tailored courses available on demand via the Reed Smith Campus learning management system
- Junior/early mid-level associates attend **Associate Advantage** — a global, three-year, iterative curriculum emphasising personal connections and professional relationships, with firm clients, alumni and leaders as faculty
- Mid-level/senior associates: experiential legal skills workshops (e.g. **Trial Training**, **Deal Clinic** — both biennial, hands-on, culminating in mock trials/complex transaction practice), plus cohort programmes (**Senior Associate Leadership** — 6 months; **Senior Associate Client Development** — 3 months) and a Senior Associate Conference on career planning
- New counsel/partners (including laterals) get multi-month programmes on expectations and leadership, plus one-on-one or group coaching

Trainee-level skills training includes

- Research strategies; effective legal writing (with 1:1 coaching)
 - Contract-drafting basics and an experiential drafting boot camp
 - Persuasive writing, brief-writing boot camp, deposition skills
 - Negotiation workshops; GenAI hands-on clinic
- Communicating with impact (with 1:1 presentation coaching)
 - Personal branding, networking, elevator pitch
 - Financial acumen, law firm economics, matter pricing
 - Delegation skills; leadership/work-style awareness; Career Footprints alumni podcast

8. Reed Smith Global Solutions

A 500+ person team rethinking legal service delivery for clients, working with in-house legal departments to re-evaluate legal needs and optimise the services they receive.

- **Innovation** — simplifies complex tasks and builds in continuous improvement processes
- **Empowering Talent** — works with clients' in-house legal and wider business to improve working processes, spot hidden and growing problems, and bring speed, agility and economies to people's work
- **Enhancing Efficiencies** — benchmarking, technology evaluation, and managing regulatory change to find real productivity, time and cost gains
- **Risk Reimagined** — combines client and firm data with market intelligence and AI tools to spot problems and opportunities otherwise missed
- **Technology Solutions** — automation of repetitive tasks, better data storage/management, easier document sharing and workflows, reducing risk exposure and freeing energy for creative thinking

9. Pro Bono & Responsible Business

Pro bono hours (2024)	70,000 hours, worth over \$50m
Charities supported yearly	Around 300
Pro bono allowance	140 hours per lawyer, per year

- Aims to expand access to justice and help people overcome legal barriers for stronger futures, through measurable initiatives
- Environmental commitment: minimises environmental impact through firmwide action, including collaboration with clients and suppliers
- Individual office "Green Teams" focus on awareness and practical solutions — resource efficiency, waste management, local community action
- London office runs on 100% renewable energy

10. Apprenticeship Structure

Reed Smith is set to welcome its **first-ever solicitor apprentices in September 2026**. Unlike schemes that focus purely on law, this one mixes legal work with exposure to business and tech functions — developing commercial awareness and digital skills, aiming to create rounded professionals rather than just lawyers.

Rotation structure (3 seat rotations per year)

- **Years 1-2:** Business services — including marketing and client value work
- **Years 3-4:** Paralegal — work closely mirroring a trainee's role, building a strong foundation to hit the ground running later
- **Years 4-6:** Trainee — four rotations of 6 months each, including a chance for an international secondment
- An Apprentice Principal (a partner) is responsible for supporting apprentices
- Rotations are designed to help apprentices discover what they enjoy, starting with smaller tasks (e.g. due diligence) to build confidence
- Pro bono work counts toward billable targets; specific employees are responsible for encouraging engagement (e.g. volunteering to help local schoolchildren read)

11. 2026 EU Regulatory Landscape

Reed Smith has prepared in-depth analysis of a wide range of incoming EU digital, product and data regulation — relevant context for the firm's cross-sector advisory work.

Digital Omnibus	EU Commission exploring streamlining of GDPR, ePrivacy, Data Act, AI rules and cybersecurity frameworks; further discussion expected early 2026
General Product Safety Regulation	In force since Dec 2024; 2025 guidance clarified scope (incl. digital/hybrid products); market surveillance expected to intensify through 2026
AI Act	In force since Aug 2024; prohibited-AI rules applied Feb 2025; main Act applies Aug 2026; remaining high-risk obligations by Aug 2027 — 2026 is the pivotal readiness year
Data Act	In force since Jan 2024; most rules apply from Sept 2025; core data-access obligations from Sept 2026
Revised Product Liability Directive	Covers digital products/software explicitly; member states must transpose by Dec 2026; webinars planned Feb 2026
Distance Marketing of Financial Services Directive	Requires a "withdrawal button" for online contract cancellation; member states to implement by June 2026
Quantum Act	Still at strategy/consultation stage; expected submission for adoption in 2026
Space Act	Feedback period closed; draft application proposed from Jan 2030
Digital Fairness Act	Targets dark patterns, marketing practices, digital product design (B2C); first draft tentatively expected late 2026
e-Evidence Regulation & Directive	Cross-border law-enforcement data access framework; emergency requests may need an 8-hour response; Directive transposed by Feb 2026, Regulation applies Aug 2026

12. Sector Deep-Dives

Energy & Natural Resources

Many separate internal teams (finance, regulatory, litigation); commodity work is frequent; close attention to contract detail matters, since minor issues (e.g. a day's delay) can cost millions. A dedicated crypto team considers environmental impact and what can legally be stored. Key trends: the move to renewable energy, the EU AI Act, and how goodwill/reputation interact with regulatory change.

Transport

Covers financing, transferring rights to a lease, and a wide range of different clients; litigation teams are affected by geopolitical issues (e.g. Ukraine/Russia). An internal training activity used the Suez Canal blockage as a case study for group discussion on liability.

Finance

A broad practice with dedicated legal researchers tracking change; clients are frequently on opposing sides of the same situation with different objectives (e.g. bank v. borrower). Clients include JP Morgan and HSBC. Trainees are handed round departments and called on to assist other teams, including crypto-related tasks.

Entertainment & Media

A market leader, covering litigation advisory and regulatory work — including film finance, music deals, and financing and rights work.

Brand & Reputation Management

Increasingly digital and data-protection focused (e.g. the UK Online Safety Act, EU AI Act) — raising open questions about whether advisory work will increasingly become litigation as regulation increases. Much of this area has no precedent yet, meaning the firm helps

create it. Covers defamation, influencer agreements, and strategic advice on AI use and brand/copy protection.

13. Open Day & Networking Notes

- Office felt modern, comfortable and creative — combining heritage and modern areas, formal and relaxed spaces, adaptable to different working styles
- Apprentices at the open day seemed genuinely happy; everyone was approachable and passionate about their sectors, with a proper understanding of the context in which their sector operates
- Early responsibility is given, but support is tailored to individual preference — some prefer to work very independently, others prefer closer check-ins, and both are accommodated
- International secondment chances were described as strong for apprentices specifically
- New ideas are genuinely welcomed — including spotting where other firms may be doing something more efficiently, or contributing to marketing/content work — without needing to give up a creative interest for a corporate career
- A corporate partner has been with the firm since they started their own training, which was seen as a strong signal of the firm's quality and culture as a place people want to stay and grow in
- Corporate work spans buy/sell/invest activity across all industry groups, offering variety; the reward of seeing a deal completed (including press coverage) and firm celebrations at deal close stood out

14. Application Guidance

- Avoid repetition; prioritise originality
- Be clear on why this specific role is of interest
- Reference all relevant work experience (WEX), including group Forage-style simulations
- Focus on yourself and your own interests, and why you want to work in this kind of environment specifically
- Research the firm, its clients, and the job description thoroughly
- Bring commercial awareness down to something concrete — e.g. a single real contract and what is genuinely changing about it — rather than staying abstract
- Relevant commercial awareness themes to reference: the move to renewable energy, the EU AI Act, the broader AI movement, and goodwill/reputation in regulatory contexts

15. Position in the Market

New US firms have significantly expanded the market in recent years, raising the question of whether prestige groupings like the Magic Circle and Silver Circle may be becoming less central to how the market is defined — worth considering when discussing Reed Smith's own positioning as an international, non-traditional player.

16. Personal Fit Notes

- The apprenticeship's business-and-tech emphasis (rather than a purely legal focus) is a strong personal draw, aligning with business interests from A-Level and exposure to a family business
- A drive to work practically, reinforced through job simulations and solicitor work experience, and a preference for professional environments with collaborative, shared-outcome work
- Not wanting to wait years via the university route while still valuing academic learning — the apprenticeship route offers a balance between sustaining that passion and full-time practical work
- An interest in identifying what other firms do more effectively and bringing those ideas back — a creative, improvement-oriented mindset the firm's open culture and welcomed new ideas seem to support directly

Sources: reedsmith.com sector, insight and careers pages; firm press materials; open day and informal networking notes. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.